treatment guidelines. "The Pfizer pill doesn't have side-effects of concern and when it becomes available, it will help those at high risk and ensure lower mortality alongside vaccination," says Dr Kirti Sabnis, an infectious diseases specialist at the Fortis hospital in Kalyan, Mumbai.

India is still administering 2.5 million doses of vaccines per day, with adults below 60 having taken 71,300 boosters till May 3. So successful has been the programme that Bill Gates called it one of the best vaccination records for a country with India's income levels. However, studies show the vaccine's impact starts wearing off after 6-9 months, particularly with new strains like Omicron. Experts insist that all adults take their booster when due, even if they are not in the high-risk category. "To reduce transmission is to end the pandemic," says Sabnis. "So even if the disease is mild and we don't get seriously ill, we must take the booster to ensure we don't become carriers. If we do have a fourth wave, boosters will also help reduce hospitalisation and death."

Experts also feel children should be vaccinated even if they are not at greater risk. "So far," says Dr Pavithra Venkatagopalan, virologist and director of the Covid task force of the Rotary Club of Madras Next Gen, "there hasn't been a significant rise in the severity of disease among children. Throughout the pandemic, their immunity has been stronger than that of adults. We are yet to know the exact reason, but kids have been having mild or no symptoms. They can, however, be carriers. And we are yet to ascertain whether the new XE variant is more dangerous for children or not."

ETERNAL VIGILANCE

What still has most doctors worried is the growing sense of complacency among people. Given the quick Covid resurgence in NCR, experts now are concerned about the upcoming Char Dham Yatra, which opens from May 6. Pilgrims are not required to provide a Covid negative report or vaccination certificate. In 2020, the yatra saw 310,000 pilgrims, and the year before, 3.2 million people visited the shrines. Such a large gathering of people in close proximity remains high-risk, particularly if mask usage is lax. Not only can the most vulnerable get infected but it may also give the virus free rein, and lead to the emergence of a new variant. Omicron is more infectious but not deadly. But even with all the advancement in Covid management and treatment, a variant akin to (or worse than) Delta could once again decimate India and the world.

Misplaced confidence that we are out of the woods will cost us, insist experts. "There is still a lot we don't know about the virus," says Dr Venkatagopalan. "We should refrain from making assumptions, and err on the side of caution." People should also ensure they duly report infections. Dr Naik points out how people in Pune do not want to upload results as they fear the government might send them to a public nursing centre. "The biggest challenge is to convince them to take responsibility as they could infect someone else if they don't disclose their results," he says.

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>
> **DR PAVITHRA VENKATAGOPALAN**
> *Virologist; Director, Covid task force, Rotary Club of Madras Next Gen*

Nor should the relative mildness of the Omicron wave lull people into complacency. "Even mild Covid is a difficult illness," says internal medicine specialist Dr T. Chandrashekhar from the Fortis hospital at Vashi in Navi Mumbai. "Many feel weak for weeks after recovery. As with all viral diseases, rest and proper treatment are important. One must give the body a chance to heal as well as protect against infecting other people." The disease also appears mild sometimes but takes a turn for the worse overnight if the infected person has poor immunity, or other comorbid conditions such as diabetes or hypertension.

Doctors are also concerned about long Covid. As in the case of 14-year-old asthma patient Raj Verma (*name changed*) from Delhi. When he got Covid three months ago in the third wave, his symptoms had largely been mild. But ever since, he has developed high sensitivity to allergens, which wasn't the case prior to his illness. "We are seeing a pattern that asthma patients upon recovery become a lot more sensitive, and many things that earlier did not trigger an attack, now do," says Dr Ashish Kumar, respiratory medicine and sleep specialist at the Medanta hospital in Gurgaon.

Likewise, doctors are continuously surprised at the impact Covid leaves on the heart, brain, liver and hormonal balance. "Covid causes a lot of inflammation, which in turn can affect just about any organ," says Mumbai-based internal medicine specialist Dr Farah Ingale. Silent symptoms such as anxiety and stress are also common. "You can experience psychological pain and stress post-Covid. There is no way to determine who will react in what manner. The safest is to take precautions against getting infected," says Mumbai-based psychiatrist Dr Kedar Tilwe.

Much as we want to wish it away, Covid is not going anywhere. "This virus is here to stay and will keep coming back," says Dr Nangia. "We need to adapt to and live with it in a manner that will protect against infection and transmission." Keep those N95s on. ■